

HOUSE No. 5277

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, March 25, 2026.

The committee on Transportation, to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 3654) of Kip A. Diggs and Thomas W. Moakley relative to establishing year-round daily commuter rail service to Cape Cod, reports recommending that the accompanying bill (House, No. 5277) ought to pass.

For the committee,

JAMES ARCIERO.

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to restoring commuter rail to Cape Cod.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. (a) Notwithstanding any general or special law to the contrary, the
2 Massachusetts Department of Transportation, in collaboration with the Massachusetts Bay
3 Transportation Authority, hereinafter referred to as MBTA, shall conduct a feasibility study,
4 hereinafter referred to as the study, relative to establishing year-round, daily rail service between
5 the towns of Falmouth, Bourne, Barnstable, Yarmouth and Sandwich and the city of Boston via
6 the Cape Cod line, Hyannis Branch line and the Woods Hole Branch line. The study shall be
7 undertaken in consultation and collaboration, to the maximum extent possible, with the New
8 England District of the United States Army Corps of Engineers, and shall seek to complement
9 and improve upon the Cape Rail Study of 2021.

10 (b) The study shall examine and evaluate the costs and opportunities related to providing
11 year-round, daily rail service between the towns of Falmouth, Bourne, Barnstable, Yarmouth and
12 Sandwich and the city of Boston including, but not limited to:

(i) the projected capital costs including the costs to upgrade the lines, signal systems, and stations for commuter rail including specific costs to upgrade tracks to each town with existing rail lines and costs to upgrade each station on Cape Cod;

(ii) the development of an operating and maintenance plan for commuter rail access to Cape Cod towns;

(iii) the prospect of operating high-speed rail service on existing rights of way and other operational issues including necessary upgrades to infrastructure;

(iv) the environmental and community impact estimates, especially on environmental justice populations as defined in section 62 of chapter 30 of the General Laws;

(v) the availability of federal, state, local and private sector funding sources including capital investments and ongoing operations and maintenance funding;

(vi) first and last mile connections within the Cape Cod rail system including Cape only train routes;

(vii) specific costs of infrastructure upgrades necessary at Middleboro and other MBTA stations to accommodate direct commuter rail access from Buzzards Bay to Boston;

(viii) any other effects deemed necessary by the MBTA in order to ensure a complete report on the funding necessary to upgrade infrastructure for commuter rail access for Cape and Island residents.

(c) The study shall determine all necessary steps the commonwealth must take to best position itself for any available or potential federal funding. Further, the study shall consider the

33 commuting patterns of residents within the service area when considering potential rail
34 schedules.

35 (d) The Massachusetts Department of Transportation shall file a report on the findings
36 and determinations of the study with the clerks of the house and senate, the chairs of the house
37 and senate committees on ways and means and the house and senate chairs of the joint
38 committee on transportation not later than 9 months after the effective date of this act.

39 SECTION 2. Not later than 12 months after the effective date of this act, the MBTA
40 shall produce a schedule for potential year-round service between Buzzards Bay station and
41 South Station, with an intermediate stop at Wareham Village station and, insofar as is feasible as
42 determined by the MBTA, schedules shall be aligned with the commuting patterns of the service
43 areas. If the MBTA determines that such service is feasible, the MBTA shall operate not less
44 than 1 AM Peak trip and 1 PM Peak trip on this route each weekday.